

# 501(c)(3) Quick Start Checklist

Your free 10-step roadmap to starting and launching a nonprofit  
501c3madesimple.com

---

## Step 1 | Define Your Mission & Vision

- Write your mission statement — one clear sentence
- Example: “To provide free dance training to underserved youth in Charlotte, NC”
- Define who you serve and what problem you solve
- Choose your nonprofit category (arts, education, community, etc.)

*Tip: Your mission statement goes directly on your IRS application. Make it specific.*

## Step 2 | Choose Your State & Incorporate

- Choose the state where you will operate
- Pick your nonprofit name and check it is available
- Search your state's business registry to confirm no one else has it
- File Articles of Incorporation with your state (typically \$50–\$150, 1–5 business days online)
- Receive your Certificate of Incorporation

*Tip: Most people incorporate in the state where they live and operate. No need to use Delaware.*

## Step 3 | Recruit Your Board of Directors

- Minimum 3 board members required by most states
- Choose people you trust — family members are allowed to start
- Assign roles: President, Secretary, Treasurer
- Hold your first board meeting and document it with minutes
- Keep these minutes — the IRS may ask for them

*Tip: Board members do not need to be experts. They need to be committed to your mission.*

## Step 4 | Write Your Bylaws

- Find or draft a nonprofit bylaws template
- Customize: board size, term limits, voting procedures, meeting frequency
- Have the board vote to adopt bylaws at the first meeting
- Store signed bylaws — you will need them for the IRS

*Tip: Bylaws do not get filed anywhere publicly — they are your internal operating rules.*

## Step 5 | Get Your EIN (Employer Identification Number)

- Go to IRS.gov and search “Apply for EIN online”
- Apply online — completely free, takes about 10 minutes
- You receive your EIN immediately upon completion
- Save your EIN confirmation letter (CP 575)

*Tip: The EIN is like a Social Security Number for your nonprofit. Free and instant online.*

## Step 6 | File IRS Form 1023 or 1023-EZ

- Determine which form you qualify for
- Most small nonprofits under \$50K/year use the 1023-EZ — much simpler
- Create an account at Pay.gov to file electronically
- Pay the filing fee (\$275 for 1023-EZ, \$600 for the full 1023)
- Submit and wait for your IRS determination letter

*Tip: The 1023-EZ is 3 pages. The full 1023 is 12+ pages. Qualify for EZ if you can — it's much faster (2–4 weeks vs. 3–6 months).*

## Step 7 | Register With Your State

- Register as a nonprofit/charity with your state attorney general
- Apply for state tax exemption (separate from federal)
- Register to solicit donations if required in your state
- About 40 states require charitable solicitation registration — check yours

*Tip: State registration is separate from the IRS. Don't skip this step or you can't legally fundraise.*

## Step 8 | Open Your Nonprofit Bank Account

- Gather: EIN letter, Articles of Incorporation, bylaws, board meeting minutes
- Choose a bank — many offer free nonprofit checking accounts
- Open the account in the nonprofit's name — not your personal name
- Set up a bookkeeping system (Wave or QuickBooks Nonprofit — both free to start)

*Tip: Never mix personal and nonprofit funds. Separate accounts protect your tax-exempt status.*

## Step 9 | Launch Your First 90 Days

- Create your nonprofit website and social media profiles
- Launch your first fundraiser or program
- Apply for your first grant (grants.gov for federal, local community foundations too)
- Begin monthly board meetings and document minutes

*Tip: Foundations and government agencies search online before awarding grants. Your digital presence matters.*

## Step 10 | Stay Compliant — Annual Requirements

- File IRS Form 990 annually (990-N for small orgs is free and takes 5 minutes)
- Renew state charitable registration annually
- Hold annual board meetings and document minutes
- Track all income and expenses from day one

**Tip:** *The #1 reason nonprofits lose their 501(c)(3) status is failing to file the annual 990. Set a calendar reminder.*

---

For more free and discounted resources for 501(c)(3) nonprofits — grants, software, product donations, and weekly nonprofit news — visit [501c3madesimple.com](https://501c3madesimple.com)

Educational information only. 501c3 Made Simple does not provide legal, tax, or financial advice.